

Mad Martiken's Menagerie of Magical Services

Slogan: *"Be whatever you want to be."*

The Wizard

Mad Martiken is a dwarf of ambiguous age, with a wiry beard that seems to shift colors from rust-red to slate-grey depending on the angle of the lamplight. His eyes glimmer with a strange, unsettling vitality—like someone who has glimpsed too many things beyond the veil of sanity, and has chosen to lean into the madness rather than resist it.

His voice carries a theatrical lilt, part carnival barker, part philosopher, part trickster. When you speak to him, you get the impression that every word has been weighed not for truth, but for effect. He *insists* that he can transform anyone into anything—creature, hybrid, monstrosity, or godling imitation—for a price. And in truth, he can. The question is always what happens after.

The Storefront

The Menagerie sits on a crooked street, impossible to miss. Its exterior walls are bedecked with the mounted heads of magical beasts: chimerae, manticores, owlbears, even what appears to be the skull of a baby kraken. Each is impeccably preserved and displayed with disturbing reverence. Some swear the heads' eyes follow them as they pass.

Inside, the shop is a kaleidoscope of taxidermied creatures, full-body displays arranged in dramatic poses as if frozen mid-battle, mid-roar, or mid-flight. The air smells faintly of incense, embalming oils, and something metallic beneath it all—perhaps blood. The lighting shifts color subtly as one moves through the aisles, casting illusions that make the stuffed creatures seem to twitch, breathe, or stir.

The Services

Martiken offers magical transfigurations in carefully tiered packages:

- **500 Gold** – A temporary change, lasting a few hours or a day at most. Ideal for disguises, intimidation, or forbidden parties.
- **1 Platinum (1000 Gold)** – A permanent cosmetic modification: changing hair to fire, skin to scales, or adding claws, gills, or exotic eyes.

- **5 Platinum** – A permanent *functional* modification, such as dragon wings, shark gills with fully aquatic lungs, or a natural venomous stinger.

Optional packages include scaling duration, reversibility clauses, and enchantments to hide the transformation until revealed.

But Martiken always provides one warning:

The magic is not always tame.

The Price Beyond Gold

Martiken explains—always with a sly grin—that some creatures’ essences are simply too assertive to graft without consequence. Gods and primordial creators tend to guard their designs jealously. To meddle with these creatures’ features is to invite cosmic interference.

Known “mutagenic risk” lineages include:

- **Dragonkind** – Draconic biology tends to overtake the host, eventually mutating them toward draconic monstrosities or erasing the features entirely.
- **Arachnids** – Known to “bloom” unexpectedly: extra eyes, mandibles, or entire legs erupting without warning. One noblewoman famously sprouted spider limbs mid-speech in her nation’s parliament.
- **Pixies & Fae** – Fey changes are notoriously unstable, often warping into capricious, reality-bending mutations.
- **Sharks** – Aquatic modifications have a habit of “going wild,” branching into a medley of sea-creature traits rather than remaining shark-specific.

Other races tied strongly to divine creators may prove equally dangerous. “Gods are jealous of their toys,” Martiken quips, “and sometimes they break *you* to spite *me*.”

The Process

Martiken requires every client to undergo a **visualization ritual**. In a smoky chamber, he guides them into vividly imagining the desired form: its shape, its texture, the sensation of moving within it. The clarity of this vision shapes the final transformation.

But he always coaches the client in *biological feasibility*. Bug wings cannot lift a human frame without magical augmentation. Extra arms must have musculature to anchor to, or else risk useless flailing. Dragon wings, while popular, are among the most dangerous long-term—because dragons, above all creatures, “do not share well.”

Once the vision is refined, Martiken lays a hand on the client’s head or shoulder. A storm of smoke, fog, and glittering motes swirls around them, engulfing both wizard and supplicant. When it clears, the change is made—whether glorious, grotesque, or both.

The Reputation

To some, Mad Martiken is a miracle-worker, an artisan of flesh and form who grants people their wildest dreams. To others, he is a blasphemer, a heretic who meddles in divine design and leaves trails of cursed wretches in his wake.

But for all the rumors and horror stories, his Menagerie never lacks for customers. Adventurers craving power, nobles seeking spectacle, and outcasts yearning for new identities all line up, coin in hand, to hear him whisper:

“Be whatever you want to be.”

The Store and Its Oddities

Mad Martiken’s Menagerie is more theater than shop, more shrine than laboratory. The moment you cross the threshold, the air feels thick, as if reality has been stretched too thin.

Illusory Structure

- **True Seeing** reveals that the **entire building is illusory**, stitched together from Martiken’s own sorcery. The walls aren’t wood, but memories of wood. The windows aren’t glass, but imitations of glass. The foundation doesn’t exist, yet feels weighty enough to hold the whole block in place.
- **Real Components:** Over the decades, genuine detritus has crept in. Dust, rats, nails, screws, spilled potions, scraps of paper—all real. The pipes are illusory, yet the water flowing through them is real because enough has been poured in by visitors. The sign’s left side is held up by actual screws hammered into nothing.

This blending of truth and lie creates a **half-demiplane**, a “bubble” in reality where his craft thrives. Martiken doesn’t fully grasp that his Menagerie is its own minor plane, feeding on his unstable genius.

Interior Oddities

- **Stuffed Displays:** Creatures ranging from cockatrices to nightmare steeds are mounted in lifelike poses. Some blink when you aren't looking. Others breathe faintly, as though caught between life and death.
- **The Glass Menagerie:** Rows of glass cases filled with bottled curiosities—a mummified pixie, a kraken's beak no larger than a child's fist, a vial of dragon's blood that refuses to stay the same color, constantly shifting hues.
- **The Gallery of Heads:** Above the counter hangs a wall of skulls and stuffed heads: a beholder (its eyestalks twitch when customers mention "True Seeing"), a unicorn with blackened horn, and something no one recognizes but everyone fears.
- **Whispering Furniture:** The chairs and tables sometimes murmur suggestions to clients during consultations—though Martiken insists he "doesn't hear a thing."
- **The Mirror of Becoming:** A full-length mirror that shows the viewer not as they are, but as they *wish* to be. Sometimes, though, it shows what they most fear. Martiken uses it during visualization sessions.
- **Odd Stock:** Shelves of strange items: claws in jars, bound grimoires that scream when opened, a collection of insect carapaces that shift colors like oil slicks.

Martiken's Magic (Unstable Origins)

Martiken is a **self-taught blend of wizard and sorcerer**, dabbling in alchemy, fleshcraft, and planar sorcery without fully understanding what he's doing. His madness both fuels and limits him. He believes he has "perfect control," but in truth, the Menagerie itself acts as a stabilizer—its demiplane nature catches the chaos of his transformations and feeds it back into reality in warped ways.

This is why his transformations work. It is also why they mutate.

The Mutagenic Tables

Whenever a character undergoes a transformation from Martiken, there is a chance (DM's discretion, usually **1d20 on completion, or at intervals of weeks/months**) that the mutation continues to evolve. Roll on the relevant table depending on the creature-feature added.

General Mutagenic Effects (d20)

1. Feature remains stable. No side effects.
2. Feature slowly fades, vanishing in a week.
3. Random patches of scales/feathers/hair sprout uncontrollably.
4. Extra eye appears somewhere on the body.
5. Voice warps—hissing, booming, or echoing oddly.
6. Appetite changes—cravings for raw meat, insects, minerals, or blood.
7. Dreams become prophetic... but nightmarish.
8. Feature becomes grotesquely oversized.
9. Host's skin occasionally ripples as though something moves beneath.
10. Feature spreads—claws become talons, eyes multiply, etc.
11. Partial transformation triggers during strong emotions.
12. New limb/head/appendage twitches with a will of its own.
13. Host develops instinctive behaviors (nesting, hoarding, predation).
14. Minor magical aura flares uncontrollably (sparks, frost, whispers).
15. Feature fuses with mundane equipment (armor grafted into skin).
16. Painful seizures precede new growth.
17. Blood becomes odd—glows faintly, smells wrong, corrodes metal.
18. Host's shadow lags behind, or looks "more transformed" than the body.

19. Sudden uncontrolled transformation surge (DM chooses effect).
 20. **Catastrophic mutation**—roll twice, both apply, effects magnify.
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Draconic Modifications (d12)

1. Horns thicken and grow uncontrollably.
 2. Eyes slit into reptilian glare, glow faintly in the dark.
 3. Breath occasionally smokes or sparks without intent.
 4. Scales spread across skin unpredictably.
 5. Tail stub begins growing.
 6. Hunger for raw meat and treasure develops.
 7. Dreams of dragon-gods whisper orders.
 8. Sudden hoarding compulsion—rocks, coins, bones.
 9. Spontaneous breath weapon discharge during stress.
 10. Limbs elongate, body slowly warps toward draconic.
 11. Partial wings twitch and spasm violently.
 12. Draconic *persona* takes root—host develops an alternate identity.
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Arachnid Modifications (d10)

1. Extra set of eyes open during night only.
2. Fine hairs sprout across skin.

3. Craving for insects intensifies.
 4. Spinnerets develop subtly—random webs produced unconsciously.
 5. Skin segments slightly, carapace growths.
 6. Mandibles erupt painfully.
 7. Extra arms bud, vestigial at first.
 8. Sudden urge to nest in dark corners.
 9. Eyes cloud over with multiple reflections.
 10. Full body tries to shift arachnid over time.
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Pixie/Fae Modifications (d8)

1. Uncontrollable glittering motes trail behind.
 2. Voice becomes musical, hypnotic.
 3. Random polymorph-like shifts occur in objects touched.
 4. Ears grow elongated and leaf-like.
 5. Illusions spontaneously manifest around the host.
 6. Personality shifts to chaotic whimsy.
 7. Shrinking episodes—temporary size reduction.
 8. Wild magic surges burst randomly.
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Aquatic/Shark Modifications (d8)

1. Teeth regrow constantly, falling out and replacing.
 2. Eyes go black, wide, and soulless.
 3. Gills ache when away from water.
 4. Fins sprout unpredictably.
 5. Skin takes on rubbery slickness.
 6. Sudden bursts of predatory rage.
 7. Dreams filled with oceans, drowning, pursuit.
 8. Body begins mutating into *random aquatic hybrids* (eel, crab, squid).
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Rare Catastrophic Mutation (d6)

1. Body undergoes partial transformation into **full creature**—uncontrolled.
 2. Mutation infects nearby beings—companions risk smaller changes.
 3. Soul partially fuses with creature's essence—loses humanity.
 4. Divine wrath—creator-god strikes, cursing with deformity.
 5. Mutation turns parasitic—the feature becomes its own mind.
 6. Reality warps—host and surroundings mutate chaotically.
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So Martiken's gift is also a curse: he gives you what you want, but the **Menagerie decides whether it stays that way**.

Mutation Trigger Rules

Mutagenic effects occur when the host's body or soul fails to fully reconcile the grafted transformation. Roll a **Mutation Trigger Check** whenever one of the following applies:

Trigger Conditions by Category

Minor Mutations (roll on Minor table)

These are the “everyday hiccups” of Martiken’s magic. Cosmetic, annoying, or unsettling, but not immediately catastrophic.

Roll when:

- The host **uses the new feature** for the first time each day.
- The host undergoes **stress** (combat, fear, exhaustion, intoxication).
- The host is exposed to **anti-magic** or dispelling fields.
- During **dreams or sleep**, roll once per week.
- Whenever the host **visualizes their own body** (mirror, scrying, illusions).

Chance of trigger: 25% (1–5 on d20).

Major Mutations (roll on Major table)

These are dangerous escalations—new limbs, psychic bleed-through, or divine backlash.

Roll when:

- A **god, patron, or planar entity** notices the blasphemous graft.
- The host **overuses** the feature (e.g., flying with new wings for hours, breathing fire repeatedly).
- A **critical success or failure** occurs while using the modified feature.
- Host **heals from near death** (0 HP, resurrection, or restoration).
- Strong **emotions** overwhelm the host (rage, grief, ecstasy).

Chance of trigger: 15% (1–3 on d20), OR automatic if conditions are extreme.

Extreme Mutations (roll on Extreme table)

Reality-bending catastrophes. The magic unravels, or the graft tries to rewrite the host entirely.

Roll when:

- Host is directly exposed to **raw magic** (wild magic surges, ley lines, unstable artifacts).
- Host attempts to **add a second or third modification** while already unstable.
- The modified feature comes into conflict with the host's **soul/lineage** (e.g., half-dragon graft + celestial bloodline).
- **Divine interference**: a jealous god strikes.
- Prolonged exposure to the demiplane of the Menagerie itself (weeks/months).
- Host deliberately attempts to **push the feature beyond limits** (e.g., trying to breathe fire continuously to melt a fortress wall).

Chance of trigger: 5% (natural 1 on d20) OR automatic if triggered by divine/planar wrath.

DM Usage

- **Step 1:** Identify the trigger (daily use, stress, divine attention, etc.).
 - **Step 2:** Roll d20 against the chance of mutation.
 - **Step 3:** If triggered, roll on **Minor**, **Major**, or **Extreme** tables depending on the event's severity.
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Quick Reference Table

Roll Type	Conditions	Chance	Example Trigger
Minor	Daily use, stress, dreams, mirrors	25% (1–5 on d20)	Breathing fire for intimidation

Major	Divine notice, overuse, criticals, near-death, extreme emotions	15% (1–3 on d20) or Auto	Resurrected after death
Extreme	Wild magic, stacking mods, divine wrath, pushing limits, long-term exposure	5% (nat 1) or Auto	Grafting dragon wings onto a fae-blooded sorcerer

DM's Notes – Dolomedes (Cat Eyes)

The Modification

- Dolo received feline eyes, granting **darkvision 60ft** and a faint glow in dim light.
 - The change is relatively minor compared to Martiken's more extreme grafts (no divine bloodline entanglement, no massive bodily restructuring).
 - The enchantment works by gently *overlaying* feline traits onto human physiology, not rewriting their soul.
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Martiken's Warning (or Lack Thereof)

Martiken barely muttered anything when finishing the spell:

"Cat's eyes? Pah. Easy work. Not even the gods bother with the little things. Unless, of course, your swamp mistress is the jealous sort—but then again, she seems the type to enjoy watching."

This half-assurance reflects the truth: **the Lady of the Swamp likely won't care about this minor tweak.** The change is cosmetic, functional, and doesn't encroach on divine "ownership" of a bloodline.

Risk Level

- **Minor Risk:** Very low chance of mutagenic events. Dolo might occasionally experience "twitches" of strangeness (pupils narrowing suddenly, eyes catching the glow of swamp lights), but nothing dramatic.
 - **Patronal Awareness:** The Lady of the Swamp *knows* of the change, but sees it as beneath her concern. In fact, she may view it as a **test of perspective**: allowing Dolo to "see the world differently" aligns with swamp mysticism.
 - **Mutation Triggers:** Only roll **Minor Mutation** if Dolo heavily abuses vision-related powers (constant Eldritch Sight, casting through illusions, scrying into forbidden realms).
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Roleplay Flavor

- **Eyes in the Dark:** NPCs might be unsettled when Dolo's pupils slit in torchlight.
- **Swamp Connection:** Their pact might "lean in," letting them perceive swamp-spirits or ghostly lights no one else sees.
- **Dream Symbolism:** Dolo may dream of the swamp watching through their eyes, a gentle reminder that their patron is *always* present.

DM's Notes – Soba (Copper Dragon Wings + Red Lineage)

Martiken's Warning

Before sealing the spell, Martiken pressed a hand to Soba's chest, cocked his head, and muttered:

“Mmm. Dragons don’t share well, lad. Red blood, copper wings... that’s two gods you’ve invited into your marrow. Somewhere between twenty and fifty years, mark me—something’s going to give. You might find yourself less Soba... more dragon. Entirely.”

He left it at that, chuckling in his usual off-putting way.

What This Means

Soba has **two draconic lineages** fighting within him: his **red half-dragon heritage** and the **copper wings grafted by Martiken**. Both carry divine echoes—Tiamat’s wrath through the reds, and the ancient trickster-breath of copper dragons. This blood-feud is now written into his flesh.

- **Timeline:** Between 20–50 years (long enough that Soba might dismiss it as “future me’s problem”), but you as DM can trigger this transformation earlier or later depending on story.
 - **Event:** The creeping “Darconic features” Martiken warned about are essentially **full dragonification**. Soba’s mortal body may slowly, or suddenly, yield to one lineage.
 - **Conflict:** Which lineage dominates—the wrathful red or the cunning copper—is unknown. It might fluctuate, fuse, or result in something new.
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Roleplay Hooks

- **Soba’s Awareness:** He knows the warning, but like many adventurers, shrugs it off as “not today’s problem.” The DM can keep teasing subtle signs over time.
- **Party Dynamics:** Other PCs might worry—*“Will Soba still be Soba in 10 years?”* This can spark tension, loyalty tests, or fear.
- **Martiken’s Words:** NPCs may reference “the copper-winged red” as an omen. Perhaps the dragonborn clans whisper prophecy of a “Darconic Scion.”

Upon the nature of his offices and buildings

It should be noted that during the party's approach and investigation of Matt Martin's menagerie it was discovered that the entire building is illusory as in fiction as in completely and utterly fabricated but it has been in place so long that it has accumulated layers of viscera and dust and gore and spattered material from sheer depth of duration of existence that the line between what is illusory and what is real is in many places deeply blurred. To the point that his second floor apartment has a sewer line that leads in 2 and is in fact actually tied into the sewer line of whatever location it happens to be currently attached to and full of shall we say material there are the bird droppings of several dozen years worth of birds roosting on the roof and about the many crannied and nooked spaces are full of insects and bugs Another minutia of dust and debris and mud and muck That one's X-ray view through say glasses of true seed reveal quite any number of unpleasant internal details about normal structures that are normally hidden from the eye behind safe walls and pipes and things that keep you from seeing the inner minutiae of a modern building and going "EW what is that !"